

Saturday, July 23, 1983

In order to make future recordings more meaningful, today's entry will lay out some of the more important events since our marriage on August 16, 1975.

Peter David Skarsgard was born June 21 1978 at City Hospital, Matthew Paul Skarsgard on September 23 1982 at St. Paul's, (*and Erik Mitchell Skarsgard on August 27 1986). These are our big-bang events. They unleashed everything else that comprise our life.

Peter is now 5 years 1 month. He wears glasses to correct a slight stigma to his left eye. He takes swimming lessons at George Ward pool, cello lessons through the Suzuki program. He plays baseball with a clean toss and carefully arranged batter's stance. He plays with Kelsey Millar, Sara Peltier, Megan Holt, Erin Bingham, Katherine Akre, Erika and Ingrid Pederson and Crystal Torgenrud (babysitter). His interests include gnomes, knights, space, cacti, prisons, mosquitoes, bees, ending of life, religion, the Bible, the farm at Canwood, Papa and Mama, medicine, eating out, music, 2-way radios, tornadoes, floods, guns, hunting, and many others things either associated with those already mentioned or spun off them by the endless questions he asks. He listens to records and tapes (favourites are Winnie-the-Pooh read by Carol Channing, Door in the Wall, Hans Christian Anderson, Raffi, Maurice Sendak's Where the Wild Things Are, Curious George, Mary Poppins, The Fantastic Mr. Fox by Roald Dahl, Radar ("Randolph") the Reindeer, Peter and the Wolf, Free to be You and Me. His favourite books include Charlotte's Web, all of Steig, The Hobbit, Shel Silverstein's Where the Sidewalk Ends, A.A. Milne, Frog and Toad, all of Roald Dahl, Grimm Fairy Tales, Wonderful Flight to the Mushroom Planet by Eleanor Cameron, Pippi Longstocking, Wizard of Oz.

Matthew is 10 months old tomorrow. He is very active and gives the impression of being even more so. He started sitting at 5 months and crawling at 7 months. He took his first steps at 9 months. He spoke his first words (ones he repeated) at 8 months: bye-bye, hi, no-no, yes, mama, dada, ba (bath). He moves things around to help him climb (dump trucks, chairs). He waves and claps his hands or whatever is in his hands. He turns knobs, flips switches, talks on his toy telephone, puts on shoes and hats, ruffles the pages of books and magazines. We

can't keep him off the musical instruments. He leans against the guitar and picks at the strings and listens, one at a time. He sits directly in front Peter when he practises and lifts the cello by its end pin. He thumps the foot-pedals of the piano and tries to move the piano bench to sit on. He drinks out of an open cup. He refuses soothers and blankets. He empties cupboards, the hamper, clears the table, tears wire from walls, shakes table lamps to the floor, breaks knobs off TVs. He is impetuous and therefore dangerous to himself. He shakes his head as if to clear his ears of water. Not once has he slept through the night; allergies and teeth wakened him as often as five or six times a night until Cheryl discovered the cause and he woke up no more than two times. Even if not for allergies and teeth, he fights sleep off, sometimes with the look of desperation, as if avoiding being drowned. If he wakes up at night he jumps to his feet and cries until either Cheryl or I lay him down and sing "Hey dum diddley dum". During the evening, if he seems to be tiring and we mention it, he climbs directly to the floor and shakes his head, though shortly, in the middle of doing something, he will topple over, sound asleep.

Cheryl runs everywhere: she takes Peter swimming or to the library; she shops for groceries or attends a stroke-improvement class at the Lathey pool (the class began with everyone hopping on one foot, dipping first the nose in the water then the ears, until she finally managed to convince the instructor that she herself has no great fears to overcome and wouldn't they get down to real laps). She is knitting an Icelandic sweater for Dawn Kasdorf. She is reading John Updike, cookbooks, the historical fiction of Stone and Mary Stewart (especially her medieval fiction), and magazines like *Woman's Day*, *Canadian Living*, *Saturday Night*, *Macleans*, *Games*. Cheryl sews her own clothes. She organizes for everyone. She spends time on the piano. She attends a cake-decorating class. Her first masterpiece was the Cookie Monster.

I am swimming every noon hour at the Phys. Ed. pool. I practise classical guitar. I am working on a Futures Problem Solving writing project for the Saskatoon Board of Education. Recently I have rough-wired and insulated the basement. I am about to install the vapour barrier and perimeter-wall gyproc. I've been reading mostly D. H. Lawrence. I oversee the lawn and garden.

Cheryl and I enjoy our family and make no apologies about being absorbed by them. When we're not doing scheduled activities we improvise. We eat out, go

for drives or visit either of our families, visit the farm, go on picnics to the Forestry Farm, bicycle and walk. When alone we watch TV programs like Lifelines (a series on medical biography), Cheers (Peter calls it the 'crazy show'; 'everyone argues'), Fawlty Towers, Newhart, Three's Company, and Masterpiece Theatre on Sunday evening. We have recently seen Bambi, Reds and E.T at the theatre. Two birthdays are coming up, and we have planned for a pizza-movie night on Wednesday.

Today has been relaxed. We visited Cheryl's grandparents to return a timer and thank them for the \$10 they sent to me for my birthday. Cheryl bought two dresses and I took Peter and Matthew to the river by the Remai building at Spadina and 20th. Afterwards we ate lunch at the Sheraton Cavalier (the decision to keep a journal was made at this time). Peter ordered grilled cheese, Cheryl and I shared a BLT, Matthew had a beef and macaroni mash half of which he sent back on the tray. Total cost: \$11.70.

We bought groceries at SuperValu. I bumped into a fellow university student, Pauline Melis. Cheryl met Cheryl Wright and talked about Marg Mack.

The afternoon was hot and sunny. We went to the George Ward pool, very noisy and crowded, very enjoyable. Peter badly wants to swim. He jumps off the blocks (he landed one directly onto a girl, and thinking she had been hurt, he cried awhile) and splashes on his own for a few feet. Cheryl and Matthew waded in the paddling end. Matthew also loves the water.

Cheryl baked a cake for my surprise birthday celebration tomorrow. Mom and Dad are coming. She cleaned the house.

Peter rode his bike and played with Megan and Devin Paterson. I cut and watered the lawns. Both boys are very tired. They slept very little today. Peter drifted off with Gnomes sitting open on his stomach. Cheryl took two pictures of Peter sitting against his headboard, one arm resting on it, legs crossed, eating a snack, talking about the dangers of diving. Just then Matthew crawled in. Peter said, "Oh oh, here comes that little shark." Cheryl is lying on the floor in a silk kimono, drying her hair with a high-speed fan. I wonder how many times Matthew will be up tonight.